was also able to locate himself and the Kremlin at the centre of a more clearly nationalist, more authoritarian, more assertive set of official ideologies which proved successful, not just in terms of his enduring popularity, but also as regards the (often forceful) unification of key sectors of the Russian political system (for a comparison with other forms of right-wing politics see Motyl 2007 and Umland 2009:5–38).

This ideology (we can call it Putinism), at once a political project and a particular vision of Russia's path to prosperity and order, was predicated on the re-emergence of Russia as a powerful international actor, and on the reconstitution of order and economic growth (Gryzlov 2007; Edinaia Rossiia 2007). One of the key virtues is a deliberate ambiguity, designed to fit myriad hues of pragmatism and nationalism into a highly concentrated, neoliberal and statist doctrinal umbrella. This is an important advantage of Putinism, and it explains why Yedinaia Rossiia (United Russia), the only successful Kremlin-backed party since 1991, continues to dominate Russian politics today. Putinism, thus understood, has essentially resolved the ideological instability which characterised Yeltsin's terms of office and, critically, makes Putin himself a guarantor of the political balance between different factions of the Russian ruling class. And of course, Putin's very rise demanded a new class balance since it launched the *siloviki* into the Russian administration, while simultaneously trying to keep business in tight proximity to the state, introducing staple neoliberal economic measures (for instance a flat income-tax rate, introduced in 2001 at the high level of 13%; or to give another example, the New Labour Code of 2001) and redistributing key economic assets into the hands of politically reliable businessmen (Sakwa 2004:96–104; Kagarlitsky 2001; see also Sakwa 2011:131–132).[1]

A third important element of the high degree of authoritarian/corporatist fusion which characterises neoliberalism in Russia concerns Russia's foreign policy, and particularly its imperial – in other accounts 'neo-imperial' or even 'trans-imperial' – character (for an overview of these different categories see especially Colás and Pozo-Martin 2011; on the neo-imperial see in particular Bugajski 2004; on the trans-imperial, see Wallander 2007; for more critical takes for and against, see Tsygankov 2006:677–679; see also Suny 2007). The formation of a bourgeois–bureaucratic amalgam described above is right at the heart of the Kremlin's international agenda and its engagement with the West. In a geopolitical context defined by ethnic fragmentation, political instability, concerns over European energy security, and NATO/EU enlargement, events such as the current conflict in Ukraine reflect something deeper than merely one-dimensional commercial, territorial or diplomatic rows (Nygren 2008, especially